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REMNANTS OF A CONVERSATION

REGARDING CONSULTANT DEVELOPMENT

Remnants of a Conversation

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REGARDING CONSULTANT DEVELOPMENT

Once upon a time in the not so distant past, I was about to launch a consultant training program. While both experience and education nurtured the thought that I was able to initiate and implement a program, I felt the ideas I was formulating would benefit with comment from others. In 2021, I invited two colleagues in Bible translation into a conversation. Inviting people with a long history in the Bible translation movement has obvious benefits, but also some drawbacks. Experience, historical perspective and awareness of current trends are obvious benefits. A potential drawback is an encumbered viewpoint, lacking a fresh perspective that avoids the trite understandings that organizational history often engenders. However, both of the people I invited are thinkers, actively developing fresh perspectives on old issues. Happily, Dr. Bryan Harmelink of Wycliffe Global Alliance and Dr. Phil King of SIL International joined the conversation.

I confess that I had an agenda. I wanted to test my ideas by holding them up to their scrutiny. As such, much of what follows is a reflection of my thoughts regarding consultant development. The wonder of dialog erupts into areas outside any agenda. In the process of conversation, new thoughts and new directions are formed. What follows is definitely not a monologue or solo exposition disguised as a conversation.

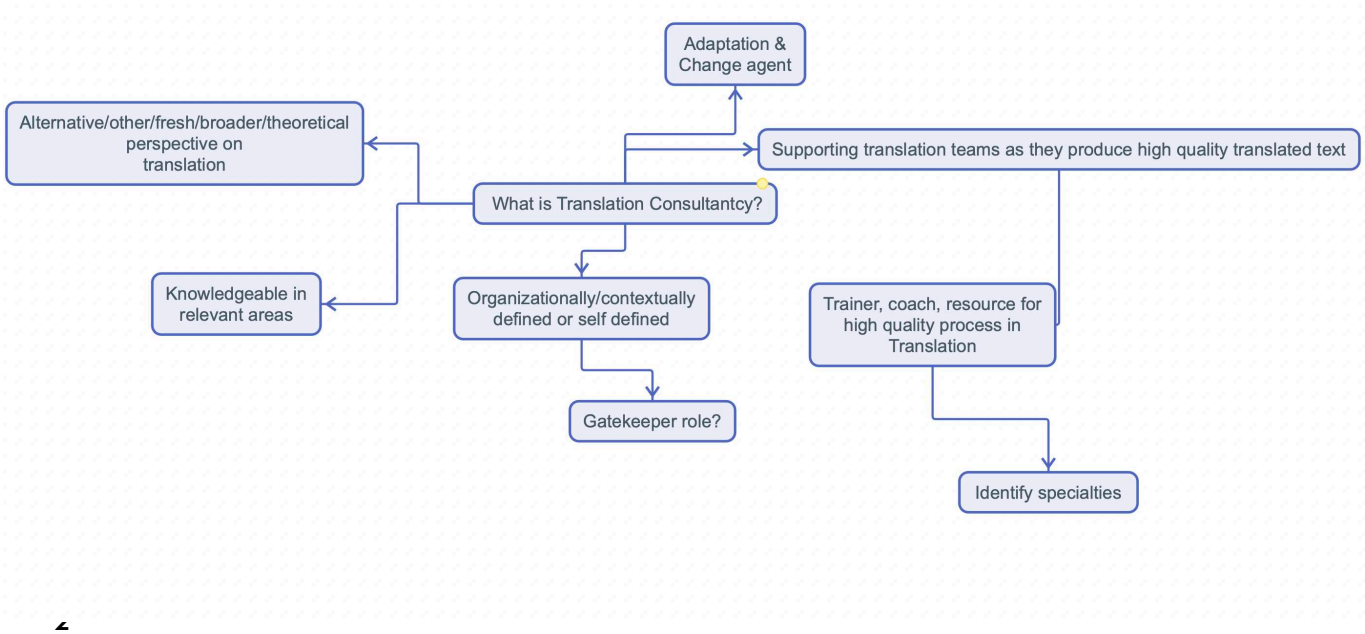
I should tell you more about the people involved in the conversation. Dr. Bryan Harmelink was SIL International's Translation Coordinator for many years. Currently he is serving as the Director for Collaboration with Wycliffe Global Alliance. Bryan completed a New Testament translation in S. America. Dr. Phil King is a senior linguistics consultant with SIL

International. Currently he serves as the International Coordinator for Translation Training and Development at SIL International. In the past, Phil has been involved in training translation consultants and others in a variety of areas including Biblical Hebrew. Both Phil and Bryan are talented speakers, and insightful planners and program developers. Dr. Roman Stefaniw has served in a variety of roles within SIL and Seed Company ranging from entity translation coordinator to area Consultant Manager to Director of Consultant Development. While serving in these roles, he has maintained direct involvement in consulting with translation teams and contributed to the development of translation consultants.

We met several times in the Fall of 2021 and our conversation ended in November. During those meetings we discussed the following topics:

- What is consultancy?
- What are fundamental tasks and skills of consultants?
- What is an outline of a consultant development program?
- What tools and materials are needed to support consultant development?

The paper that follows will include my current reflections on our past conversations and illustrations that map them. The diagrams precede the comments that explain them.



FIRST CONVERSATION : WHAT IS CONSULTANCY?

As we began to talk, Bryan suggested we address a foundational question: What is translation consultancy? Even though I would have phrased it differently, it was easy to see that addressing this question was essential to our discussion.

How would I have phrased it? Several variations are apparent. What is a translation consultant? What is a translation consultant's role? But consultancy has a professionally academic quality, so I stayed with it.

Why is this question foundational? The the explication of the role influences pathways for development. If we define the role according to translation consulting as it is currently practiced, we propagate the status quo. Consultant development programs aim at meeting current demands and filling recruitment quotas. Consultant activity is focussed on reviewing vernacular Bible translations and enhancing their quality while interacting with translation teams. In best case scenarios, the capability and performance of translation teams is also enhanced. A fundamental assumption inherent in this approach is that the future will be what the present is and the past has been.

Any approach to defining translation consultancy and building a consultant development program must take the present situation into account. A viable approach to consultant development includes a perspective extending to the horizon shaped by the past, and moving into a present that is not static but exploding with possibilities. It prepares people for maintaining current activity while fostering the development of emerging trends. Defining translation consultancy enfolds past and present in activity that anticipates and explores our future.

As we discussed this question, several summary statements described the current situation. Translation consultancy involves "**supporting translation teams** as they produce high quality translated text." This support takes many forms. People provide training in translation processes that address translation problems, linguistic issues, and resolve exegetical conundrums. As teams apply this knowledge in their translation practice, some people coach them to facilitate right application of the skills they have learned. Consultants also benefit teams as a resource, providing specialized knowledge

that aids the team as they translate. Specialized knowledge of Biblical languages or the geography of Bible lands are resources that enhance translation quality.

Are people who provide training in translation skills, who coach translation teams as they apply their knowledge, and who serve as resources in technical areas translation consultants? Quite simply, no. Translation consultants do these things, but so do others. Faculty at seminaries and universities can provide specialized knowledge of topics related to Bible translation such as enhancing the knowledge of Biblical languages. IT professionals support translation teams by teaching them to use software used in Bible translation. Currently in the Bible translation world, various supporting roles exist. People manage finances, organize personnel, provide encouragement, or actively guide translation teams as they produce Bible translations. Textbooks and guidebooks exist that thoroughly discuss translation processes, identify and resolve linguistic issues in translation, and teach how to resolve translation problems. Competent teachers use this material to teach people the basics of Bible translation. Personnel who fill these roles interact with translation teams, but are not translation consultants. Bible translation consultants do these things, and more.

Supporting translation teams in these ways is not unique to translation consultancy. While not being unique, Bible translation consultants act in these roles to support Bible translation teams. Thinking mathematically, these roles do not define translation consultancy but are elements of the set describing translation consultant activities. In our discussion, we recognized that individual translation consultants may emphasize areas in which they are particularly skilled during their interaction with teams.

Translation entities would benefit from identifying the specialties of consultants. Often consultants have specific areas of interest. All consultants should be competent in these areas, but some consultants have mastery level skill as translation trainers, in Biblical languages, in Paratext and related programs, in New Testament or Old Testament studies, in exegesis, in cultural hermeneutics, or in consulting skills. Identifying consultant specialties would allow agencies to match teams and consultants strategically. Urgency for a consultant may override strategic matching, but having the ability to match is a capacity worth developing.

As we considered the question “What is translation consultancy?” we discussed the influence of the **defining agent** on the nature of translation consultancy. If an organization is the defining agent, then qualities inherent in the organization are likely to be reflected in the definition. If the context - defined here as capabilities required to produce a quality Bible translation - is the defining agent, then a consultant would be someone who nurtured those capabilities in Bible translation teams. If translation consultancy is self defined by individuals currently serving as Bible translation consultants, then a number of factors based in individual preference and experience may contribute to defining translation consultancy. Individuals rooted in historically developed current consulting practices, people familiar with professional literature describing consultancy in other fields, and the ardent voices of advocates of a particular approach to Bible translation may each offer a definition.

Surveying the previous paragraph, suggests that all the defining agents I mentioned are needed for an adequate definition of translation consultancy. Organizations have operational constraints and a functional perspective. The context of Bible translation provides the core which organizations and individuals include in their Bible translation practice. Individuals generally have a perspective more responsive to change and more adaptive than organizations.

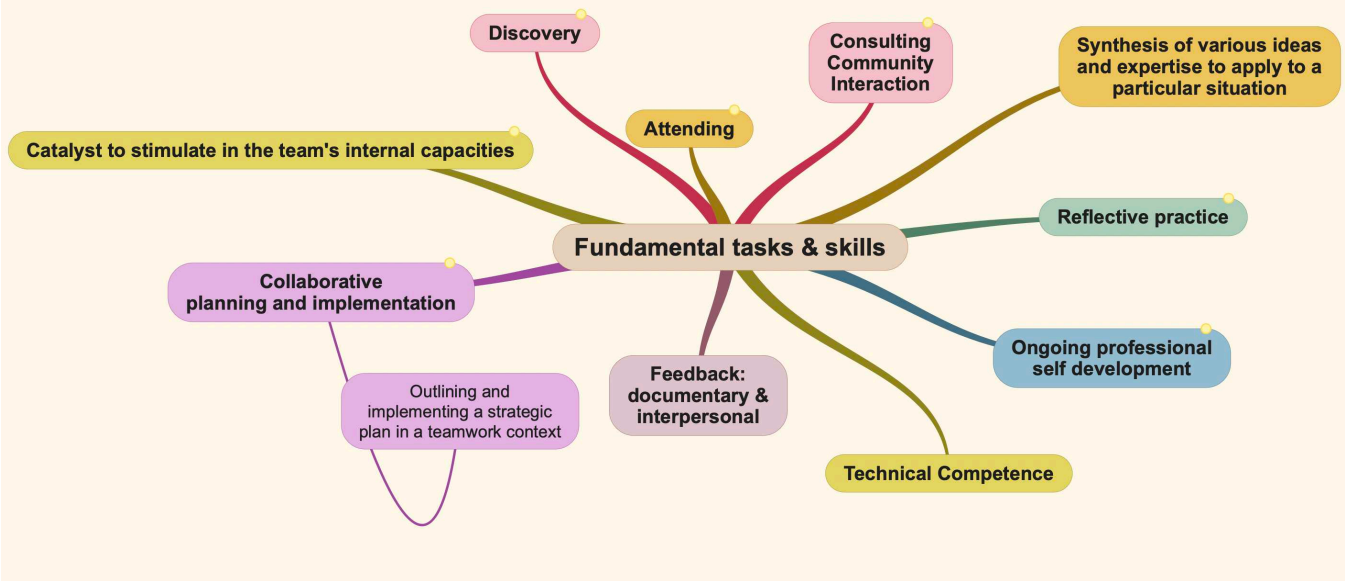
Currently there is no central authority defining translation consultancy. FOBAI (Forum of Bible Translation Agencies International) is, as its name states, a forum of agencies. These agencies ascribe to a set of recommendations for translation consultants. It has no authority to police the application of these recommendations so it cannot be considered to be a central authority. However, FOBAI is respected and considered by member agencies as they formulate practice.

We considered whether the consultant has the role of **gatekeeper** or not. Translation consultants and translation agencies may not be agreed regarding assigning Bible translation consultants the final voice on whether a translation is fit to be published. Some feel that a professional review by a consultant skilled in Bible knowledge, Biblical languages, and the art of Bible translation seals the quality of a Bible translation as fit for publication. Others consider that the community is the ultimate authority. The complexity of the issues involved suggest that this discussion will not be resolved for some time, if ever. Certainly consultant review and community review and approval are both essential

when skillfully implemented. Personally, since the community leaders and members make up the audience for the translation, I favor the view that they should be the final authority as they exercise an informed decision process. Responsible communities welcome consultant comment.

In order to fulfill their responsibilities as consultants, we stated that consultants should be **knowledgeable in relevant areas**. A minimal list of those areas includes Biblical studies, Biblical languages, target language cultures and Bible translation practices. Knowledge of target language cultures includes awareness of languages spoken by members of the cultural community. An expanded list of relevant areas includes fields such as textual criticism, Biblical archaeology, discourse, literary criticism, translation studies, and consulting practices. Some translation agencies cooperated to develop a list of skills and knowledge areas for translation consultancy as they instituted a Competency Based Certification program for translation consultants. FOBAI published guidelines for translation consultants and is currently revising those guidelines.

SIL International has made significant contributions to Bible translation training. This training is rooted in books by Beekman, Larsen, and Barnwell. More recently a text by Hill et.al. has been included in this foundational corpus. Individuals who gained translation experience in SIL or related agencies have benefited from this foundation in Bible translation but may not have expanded their awareness in other areas. In our discussion, we suggested that consultancy has an alternative, fresh, broader, and theoretical perspective on Bible translation that includes and supplements the foundational readings mentioned above. This can be gained by readings in the broader field of translation studies. Susan Barnett, Anthony Pym, Christiane Nord, Andre Lefevere, Robert Alter, and Lawrence Venuti are a few of the writers that provide and generate other perspectives. Currently, consultants are reading these authors as well as others. Stating that consultancy involves alternative, fresh, broader and theoretical perspectives in Bible translation suggests that concepts promoted by these authors should be included in training programs.



SECOND CONVERSATION : FUNDAMENTAL TASKS AND SKILLS.

Our next conversation addressed the fundamental tasks and skills which a training program should develop in consultants. Again, we addressed a wide range of topics. These topics reflected our experience and a distillation of our thoughts regarding consultancy. We made no attempt to order these by importance or develop them extensively. Our aim was to set a constellation in place where each element was a reference point for expansion. As I look at the items we listed, some overlap between categories is evident.

Consultants must be skilled at **discovery**. Discovery generates knowledge of the present situation in the context of the past. Discovery uncovers the who, what, how, and why of the consulting situation. Discovery is multilevel, investigating the local project as it is situated in personal, community, religious, and political contexts. Discovery is multidimensional, considering text, oral, and multimedia instruments. Discovery is dialectic, resulting from conversation and interaction where understandings are then shared with the community to test their validity.

We agreed that a consultant should capably serve as a **catalyst** to stimulate a translation team's internal capacities. Hosting an interactional relationship where the team realizes

that they are welcome to question the consultant is a step in this process. Another occurs when the consultant facilitates the team's engaging in self examination. A third internal capacity that consultants foster is the team's ability to conduct self review. Consultants perform an external review, but this external review of a Bible translation does not have the same perspective or the same qualities as an internal review can have. Guiding teams to engage in a team internal review that does not degrade into accusations, recriminations, or excuses is a worthwhile skill.

Enhancing a translation team's capacity for **collaborative planning and implementation** is another task we discussed. Consultants not only use this collaborative approach themselves but develop strategies that result in translation teams collaborating internally and with external partners. Implementing participatory methods for translation and engaging in planning within local communities provide a pathway for greater collaboration.

Feedback is part of the learning cycle. For a consultant to present feedback is not enough. To be effective feedback must be received. The manner in which consultants present feedback influences the manner in which it is received. Will it be received and filed, or will it be received and implemented? Consultant development should enable consultants to present feedback which is recognized as worthwhile and implemented, whether this feedback is presented in a document or interpersonally in conversation.

Mastery level skill in technical areas is essential to a consultant. These are listed in the previous section where I discuss our first conversation. A few general comments are worth making here. Consultants should have **technical competence** at an advanced or mastery level in all the areas that Bible translators need competence. In addition, mastery level competence as a consultant is necessary. Consulting involves contracting or clarifying the interaction between the consultant and clients (translation team). Consultants perform discovery and data collection activities by interacting with translation personnel, texts, and the local community to understand the translation situation. To understand the texts, knowledge of the language comes from conversation with a translation team as well as reading and study. Translation consultants provide feedback on the contents of the text and facilitate a decision to change where needed while reviewing the text. With every decision to change and make an adjustment,

consultants promote engagement and implementation by maintaining a high level of participation as the team resolves issues of varying difficulty.

The Bible translation movement seems to be in a sort of Renaissance era, filled with growth and change. Even if this were not so, a fundamental task for translation consultants involves engaging in **ongoing professional development**. In the current environment it is a necessity. To be effective in guiding teams, being up to date with translation tools, helpful materials, strategies, and professional literature requires time and attention. Not pursuing professional development risks becoming reactionary and building an idealogical fortress around established practices.

Areas for professional development mirror technical competencies already discussed. Among these are maintaining skill with Biblical languages, studying developments in Biblical studies, and improving skill at coaching and consulting.

Training translation consultants includes developing habits necessary for **reflective practice**. Practitioners employing reflective practice pass through a cycle of activity. Action leads to reflection on that action which observes, analyzes, and revises. This leads to revising the action, then reflection, then revised activity etc. Reflective practice is not only useful for problematic situations but also for improving currently acceptable situations. Engaging in reflective practice enables consultants to function creatively and responsively.

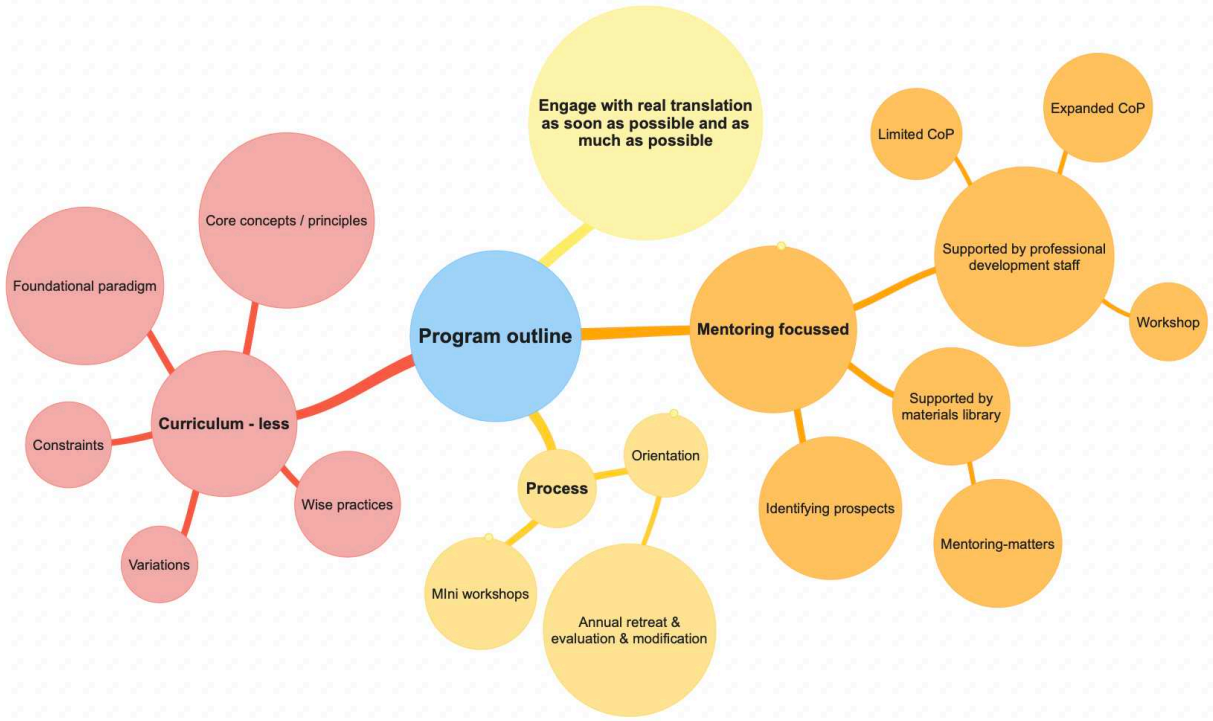
While some consultants develop and practice this skill, pressures for productivity hinder others. Literature that can support training in this area includes David Kolb's *Experiential Learning* published in 1970. By encouraging and facilitating the development of reflective practice by consultants as they are forming their approach to Bible translation consulting during their training, reflective practice becomes a functional and regular part of their activity. I have attached a brief bibliography list of materials discussing reflective practice.

Consultants are problem solvers. There are multiple methods for solving problems. Deductive methods and inductive methods are two of them. Because Bible translation consulting is an intersection of several disciplines, each of them complex, training strategies that enable consultants to **synthesize various ideas with the expertise to**

apply them to a particular situation are needed. Gaining insight into ideas that are productive in other fields is a necessary step toward incorporating them to solve particular dilemmas faced by consultants.

Consultants are not spectators, but participants **interacting in the consultant community**. While some people entering a training program may be more retiring or hesitant to put themselves forward, a consultant training program finds ways to include them in the consultant community, invites their active participation, and encourages them toward productivity. Productivity might take the form of writing academic papers, participating in community of practice meetings, presenting at conferences, or contributing in focus groups. Hearing the perspectives of newcomers opens the door for greater participation when they are more experienced.

Attending was the final task we discussed. Consultants who do not hear what translation team members or others say because their own voices are too dominant, have not developed this ability. Attending involves the whole person - attitudes toward others, physical posture, focussing vision and activity in the moment, listening and hearing, and responding appropriately. Here at the end of this section, attending summarizes the fundamental tasks and skills needed by a translation consultant, and with a bit of imagination it can be taken to be a component of the others mentioned.



THIRD CONVERSATION : OUTLINE OF A CONSULTANT TRAINING PROGRAM

Our third conversation started with the outline I presented. We did not construct an outline for a program together. My purpose at this stage of our discussion was to present the core ideas of a program and invite comment from others.

Certain values orient the outline. Realizing that consultants are skilled individuals with a unique constellation of abilities, the consultant development program takes this into account. Simplicity is important. Some complexities are unavoidable, but removing unneeded complications from the path of those learning consultancy and those guiding the development of translation consultants was another goal.

The overarching goal that permeated design and activity motivated plans for participants in the program to **engage with real translation as soon as possible and as much as possible**. In other words, keep activity not directly engaged with a consulting event to a minimum. Zero is the clearest minimum. Learning happens in real time in a real context.

Exercises where skills are practiced out of a consulting context flow out of a curriculum. In order to invite individualization, I aimed for a **curriculum-less program**. Rather than develop a curriculum to guide activity, steps in the consulting process provide that guide. Researching the consulting situation involves investigating the target language and the translation project. Preparing for consulting means thinking about the consulting situation, contacting the translation team, and reviewing the vernacular translation and preparing questions and comments. Engaging in consulting is a conversation with the translation team where potential translation issues are investigated with the translation team. This is done by identifying them, discussing them, and revising when needed. Concluding consulting includes an in-person final debrief with the translation team that summarizes interaction and presents suggestions, and a written report to the team and their supervisors. A program without a curriculum is not a program without structure. The internal structure of the consulting event guides activity rather than an external curriculum.

We discussed components of a curriculum-less program. Regarding content, core concepts and principles that comprise translation consulting guide the choice of

content. Because consultants work in varied situations and face a variety of challenges in their work, ability to understand and respond well to variations in multiple contexts should be enhanced. Rather than a curriculum guiding training, skill is built by passing on wise practices of high performing consultants. Understanding and functioning effectively within constraints, whether these are personal, environmental, or political is another principle that guides activity. A foundational paradigm of the program is implementation according to concepts and principles rather than according to a curriculum.

But still, particulars need to come from somewhere. If they are not derived from a curriculum how do the particular activities of a curriculum-less consultant development program appear? Answering this question leads to another major hub of this program. Instead of located in a plan, **consultant development is embodied in a mentor**. Skilled consultants who are capable mentors are essential to implement a personalized consultant development program. A constellation of supporting activities and materials builds the capacity of mentors.

Consultants need training and experience to develop and then enhance their skill as mentors. Books on mentoring as well as training courses are available. Websites like mentoring-matters.org offer materials and courses in the Bible translation context. Many other websites present material from a business context.

Matching participants in the program with consultant mentors needs to be done skillfully. Part of supporting mentors involves carefully identifying candidates who have requisite skills and attitudes, and are a good interpersonal fit. This identification is not a one time event but a process leading to a partnership.

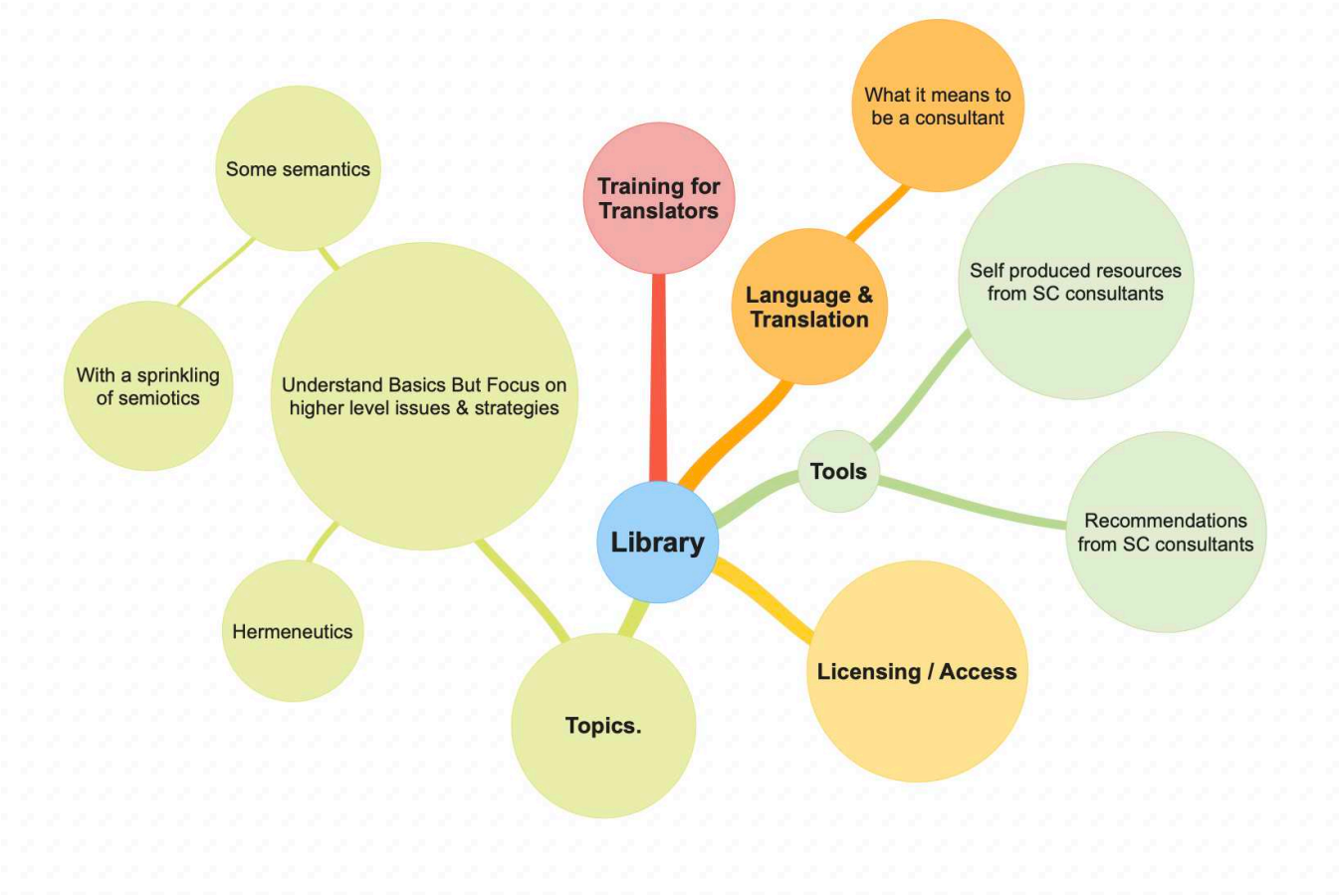
Skilled mentors should be supported by a **library of materials** that they can use or adapt as they work with mentees. These materials provide breadth and depth to mentoring; fostering and expanding the skills of mentors. Developing these materials contributes to mentors fulfilling their responsibility capably. Where a library does not yet exist, mentors are left to culling resources off the internet or obtaining recommendations from colleagues. Both of these are viable approaches to accessing resources, but a library of proven resources simplifies and expedites the process.

Not all mentors will be strong in every area of translation consulting. Mentors will be supported by a professional development staff. Specialists in particular areas of Bible translation consulting offer instruction in their area of expertise to groups of participants who have demonstrated a need for growth in that area.

Mentoring is a relational activity. The relationship between a mentor and mentee exists vertically, between an experienced practitioner and a novice. Horizontal relationships also contribute to professional growth. A **limited community of practice** that gathers around a particular task such as reviewing Genesis or understanding language features that affect Bible translation in a certain region facilitates horizontal relationships. If the consultant development program has many participants, ad hoc small groups can be formed from time to time.

Participants should also be introduced to **expanded communities of practice** by their mentors. From time to time, all the participants in the program should gather and explore different issues in translation consulting together. In addition to these, participants should be encouraged to become part of the larger Bible translation community by attending conferences, signing up for the BT list, and joining larger communities of practice. Coming into contact with groups of consultants whose interests they share provides an opportunity for learning.

Implementing this program is not complex. Individuals are selected and invited into the program. An **orientation meeting** lays out the pathway for growth, and begins connecting mentors and mentees. Limited communities of practice where groups can develop their skills in a particular area individualize skill building. In addition, I suggested an **annual retreat that addresses spiritual development as well as provides an opportunity for participatory evaluation of the program**. Self reflection as a group may illuminate needed modifications in planning or performance.



FOURTH CONVERSATION : A LIBRARY FOR CONSULTANT MENTORS

Mentors are the key to a curriculum free consultant development program. They would need to be able to identify areas requiring growth with their mentees. Then they would need strategies and materials readily available that they could use for facilitating growth in those areas. Our fourth conversation discussed a **library for consultant mentors**.

We listed topics to include. Materials should **facilitate understanding of basic principles** in their area, but not stop there. We recognized that there should be a **strong focus on higher level issues and strategies**. With these guiding principles, we included study of hermeneutics, semantics, and semiotics. Applying knowledge of these areas to Bible translation means more than being able to talk about them. It means recognizing hermeneutic, semantic, or semiotic processes as they occur during Bible translation.

Materials for training translators are part of this library. Consultants facilitate professional growth among translation teams, so they need to become skilled at using these materials. Luke Partnership training materials are one set of translator training materials that come to mind. Steve Payne has modified these and produced a library of training materials. Bryan Harmelink has developed a course entitled "Language and Translation". The topic "What it means to be a consultant" is discussed in that course.

The consultant development course I was planning was for Seed Company. Seed Company consultants are skilled and resourceful. Recommendations from Seed Company consultants as well as materials developed by Seed Company consultants generated additions to the library.

Several of the ideas we discussed are being implemented. The Digital Training Library was in early stages of development but is now growing into a resource library for translators and consultants. Mentoring has been part of consultant development for some time. The nature and extent of mentoring is developing. Training courses for mentoring are available commercially and through SIL. Searching the internet reveals many resources useful for consultants. Still more are being developed by agencies such as Eten's Innovations Lab. It is a good day for consultant development.

Consultant training courses have been offered for some time. Many of these were occasional, as agency leaders saw the need for consultant development and organized a course. Some, like SIL Asia's Translation Consultant Development Workshop (TCDW) existed semi annually and then annually since the early part of this century. Seed Company has recently launched a consultant training internship program. Translation agencies in Africa are collaborating to reinstitute consultant training activities. These are a few of the consultant development initiatives I am aware of, but I am confident that there are more. Perhaps people involved in consultant development, or considering consultant development initiatives will benefit from the remnants of the conversation described in this paper. Skilled consultants working with capable translation teams cooperate to produce quality translations.

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